

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Finance English

Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

02 Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

03 FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

04 Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

06 Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

07 Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

08 Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Revenue - Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules.

Operating income - Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation.

Variance - Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period.

Sensitivity - Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
 - B. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - C. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?
 - B. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - C. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An invoice covers services delivered in December but was paid in January. A colleague asks which month should appear in the close schedule.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Accrual - An accounting estimate recorded before cash payment or receipt occurs.

Deferred revenue - Cash received before revenue is recognized.

Working capital - Operational assets and liabilities such as receivables, inventory, and payables.

Reconciliation - Process of comparing records and resolving differences.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - B. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - C. Could you confirm when does the review start?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - B. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - C. Who will present the report at the meeting?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

The forecast shows \$120,000 of spending against a \$100,000 budget. A new supplier fee accounts for \$15,000; the remaining \$5,000 is under review.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Budget - Approved financial plan for a period.

Forecast - Updated estimate of future performance based on current information.

Variance - Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period.

Bridge - Step-by-step explanation from one financial number to another.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Improve this sentence: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team has completed the review.
 - B. The team is completing the review.
 - C. The team plans to complete the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - B. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.
 - C. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A cash forecast assumes a large customer pays on Friday. The customer has not confirmed payment. A manager asks if the cash balance is guaranteed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Liquidity - Ability to meet obligations when due without unacceptable loss or disruption.

Cash runway - How long available cash is expected to last at current or projected burn.

Revolver - A revolving credit facility that can be drawn and repaid within agreed limits.

FX exposure - Potential financial impact from movements in foreign exchange rates.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

A portfolio return is 6% before fees. Its benchmark returned 5% over the same stated period. A slide does not identify fee treatment.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Return - Gain or loss on an investment over a period, usually expressed as a percentage.

Benchmark - Reference index or target used to evaluate performance.

Volatility - Degree of price movement or variability over time.

Attribution - Analysis explaining sources of portfolio return or relative performance.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A credit file is missing an updated financial statement. The review team needs it for a scheduled meeting on Thursday.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Credit risk - Risk that a borrower or counterparty does not meet obligations.

Collateral - Assets pledged to support repayment or reduce loss severity.

DSCR - Debt service coverage ratio; cash flow relative to required debt payments.

Probability of default - Estimated likelihood that a borrower defaults.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - B. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - C. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - B. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - C. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm.

SITUATION

A reconciliation has three unmatched entries. Their cause is unknown. The preparer is handing the work to a reviewer at the end of the day.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Internal control - Process designed to provide reasonable assurance around reporting, operations, or compliance.

Control deficiency - A control design or operating issue that may allow errors or misstatements.

Reconciliation - Process of comparing records and resolving differences.

Segregation of duties - Dividing responsibilities to reduce error or fraud risk.

3. Notice the language

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

Improve this sentence: Someone should follow up on this.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Transfer information and responsibility

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence checks that responsibility has been accepted?
 - A. I mentioned the check in my earlier email.
 - B. The check appears somewhere in the notes.
 - C. Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.
2. Which response best checks a critical handoff detail?
 - A. I saw the message, so no clarification is needed.
 - B. So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?
 - C. I assume all results are final, so we can finish.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A valuation model changes materially when the growth assumption moves from 2% to 4%. The presentation shows only the higher estimate.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

DCF - Discounted cash flow valuation based on projected cash flows and discount rate.

WACC - Weighted average cost of capital; a common discount-rate input.

Enterprise value - Value of the operating business, often before deducting net debt.

Sensitivity - Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response, not a script to memorize. Your written version needs a subject line, an opening, and appropriate context. Assess it using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: C - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

B: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

C: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

Check 2: B - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

B: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

C: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

Model response: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Financial Statements, Close, and Accounting Judgments

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: B - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

B: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

C: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

Check 2: A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

B: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

C: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

Model response: Are we discussing the cash payment date or the accounting period for the expense? The payment was in January; the accounting treatment needs to follow our policy and the service details.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | FP&A, Budgeting, Forecasting, and Variance Analysis

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: A - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

B: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

C: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

Check 2: C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

B: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

C: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

Model response: Spending is forecast to be \$20,000 above budget. The supplier fee explains \$15,000 of that variance. We are still reviewing the remaining \$5,000 and will update the bridge tomorrow.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Treasury, Cash, Liquidity, Working Capital, and FX

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: The forecast assumes payment on Friday; that date is not confirmed. I'll show the balance both with and without the receipt so the team can see the liquidity exposure.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Markets, Investments, Performance, and Client Communication

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The figures suggest a one-percentage-point difference before fees. We should label fee treatment and confirm the comparison basis before describing the performance to a client.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Banking, Credit, Lending, and Counterparty Risk

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: A - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

B: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

C: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

Check 2: C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

B: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

C: The requested action and information are explicit.

Model response: Could you send the latest approved financial statements through the secure channel by Wednesday? Please confirm the reporting period, or let us know when the documents will be available.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Controls, Audit, Compliance, Fraud, and Ethics

Editing example: Please confirm which team has accepted the follow-up task.

The revised sentence asks for an identifiable receiving team instead of leaving responsibility with an unspecified 'someone'.

Check 1: C - Please confirm who will complete the outstanding check.

A: Mentioning a task does not show that anyone accepted it.

B: A written record alone does not identify who will act.

C: It asks for an identifiable person or team responsible for the task.

Check 2: B - So the result is pending and your team will follow up; is that correct?

A: Receiving a message is not the same as confirming its meaning.

B: This repeats the status and responsibility and invites correction.

C: It changes pending information into a final result.

Model response: Three entries remain unmatched. I've listed their references and the checks already completed. Please review the supporting records and record the resolution; the cause is still unconfirmed.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Valuation, M&A, Capital Allocation, and Executive Finance

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The valuation is sensitive to the growth assumption. I'll present both scenarios and explain the assumptions behind them. The higher figure is a modeled outcome, not an assured transaction value.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Investor.gov: investing glossary

<https://www.investor.gov/introduction-investing/investing-basics/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Finance English

Professional audience: accounting, FP&A, treasury, banking, investments, audit, risk, corporate finance, and finance-adjacent teams

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Finance Communication: Drivers, Assumptions, Materiality, Risk

Original fictional case: Revenue is 5% above budget, while operating profit is 2% below budget. A manager wants a one-sentence explanation for a review meeting.

Language workshop: Make a complex point clear

Communication goal: Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Language guidance: Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): In this context, ... means / The difference is that / How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Vocabulary: Revenue: Income from delivering goods or services, recognized under applicable accounting rules. / Operating income: Profit from operations before items such as interest and taxes, depending on presentation. / Variance: Difference between actual and comparison point such as budget, forecast, or prior period. / Sensitivity: Analysis showing how results change when an assumption changes.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Revenue exceeded budget, but higher operating costs more than offset the increase. I'll show the main cost drivers so the review explains why profit moved differently from revenue.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level